Common Errors Made by Students While Using English

Categorization and Examples

Vocabulary Errors

- Word Choice
- Overgeneralization
- Homonyms and Homophones
- Misusing Collocations
- Phrasal Verbs
- Contextual Word Use

Word Choice

- Non native speakers often struggle while choosing appropriate words in English
- **Confusion between adjectives and nouns:**

  Using "boring" (adjective) instead of "bored" (adjective) when describing their own feelings.

Example: "I’m very boring" should be "I’m very bored" when referring to how they feel.

- **Misusing intensifiers or qualifiers:**

  Using "too much" instead of "very" to intensify adjectives, leading to incorrect meanings.

Example: "I am too much happy" instead of "I am very happy."

Overgeneralization

- Non-native speakers In their effort to apply learned rules consistently, may overgeneralize vocabulary or word forms. For example:
- **Pluralization:** Adding "s" to all nouns to make them plural, even when irregular forms exist.
  - *Example:* "Childs" instead of "children" or "sheeps" instead of "sheep."
- **Comparative and Superlative forms:** Adding "er" or "est" to adjectives that require "more" or "most."
  - *Example:* "Beautifuller" instead of "more beautiful."

Homonyms and Homophones

- English contains many words that sound the same but have different meanings or spellings, which can confuse learners.
- **Homonyms:** Words that are spelled and pronounced the same but have different meanings.
  - *Example:* "Bat" (the animal) vs. "bat" (used in baseball).
- **Homophones:** Words that sound the same but are spelled differently and have different meanings.
  - *Example:* "There" (a location) vs. "their" (possessive) vs. "they’re" (they are).

Misusing Collocations

- A collocation is a natural combination of words that native speakers typically use together. Errors occur when learners combine words in ways that are grammatically correct but sound awkward to native speakers.
- *Example:* "Do a mistake" instead of "make a mistake."
- Another example: "Strong tea" (correct) vs. "powerful tea" (incorrect).

Make vs. Do

Incorrect: Do a decision.

Correct: Make a decision.

Incorrect: Make homework.

Correct: Do homework.

Big vs. Large

Incorrect: A large problem.

Correct: A big problem.

Incorrect: A big amount.

Correct: A large amount.

Strong vs. Powerful

Incorrect: A powerful tea.

Correct: A strong tea.

Incorrect: A strong engine.

Correct: A powerful engine.

Pay vs. Give

Incorrect: Give attention.

Correct: Pay attention.

Incorrect: Give a visit.

Correct: Pay a visit.

Break vs. Miss

Incorrect: Break a chance.

Correct: Miss a chance.

Incorrect: Miss a record.

Correct: Break a record.

Deep vs. Heavy

Incorrect: A heavy sleep.

Correct: A deep sleep.

Incorrect: A deep smoker.

Correct: A heavy smoker.

Keep vs. Save

Incorrect: Keep money.

Correct: Save money.

Incorrect: Save a promise.

Correct: Keep a promise.

Tell vs. Say

Incorrect: Tell sorry.

Correct: Say sorry.

Incorrect: say a lie.

Correct: Tell a lie

Win vs. Beat

Incorrect: I won him in tennis.

Correct: I beat him in tennis.

Incorrect: She beat the competition.

Correct: She won the competition.

Heavy vs. Strong

Incorrect: Heavy man.

Correct: Strong man

Incorrect: Strong smoker.

Correct: Heavy smoker.

Spend vs. Waste

Incorrect: Spend time on something useless.

Correct: Waste time on something useless.

Incorrect: Waste money on useful things.

Correct: Spend money on useful things.

Gain vs. Earn

Incorrect: Gain money.

Correct: Earn money.

Incorrect: Earn weight.

Correct: Gain weight.

Phrasal Verbs

- Phrasal verbs (verbs combined with prepositions or adverbs that change their meaning) are particularly challenging for learners. The meanings of phrasal verbs are often idiomatic, which makes it difficult for students to infer them from the individual words.
- *Example:* "Give up" means to quit, but students might interpret it as "give" something "up" (physically handing something to someone).
- Another example: "Run out of" means to deplete, but students might confuse it with running outdoors.

1. Break

Break down – To stop functioning (for machines) or to lose emotional control.

Example: "The car broke down on the highway."

Example: "She broke down in tears."

Break up – To end a relationship or meeting.

Example: "They decided to break up after three years."

Break into – To enter a place by force, usually to steal.

Example: "Someone broke into the house last night."

2. Look

Look after – To take care of someone or something.

Example: "She looks after her younger brother."

Look up – To search for information (often in a dictionary or online).

Example: "I need to look up this word in the dictionary."

Look forward to – To anticipate something with excitement.

Example: "I'm looking forward to the party."

3. Take

Take off – To remove (clothing) or for an airplane to leave the ground.

Example: "Please take off your shoes."

Example: "The plane took off at 9 AM."

Take up – To start a new hobby or activity.

Example: "I've taken up yoga recently."

Take after – To resemble someone, usually a family member.

Example: "She takes after her mother."

4. Get

Get along (with) – To have a good relationship with someone.

Example: "They get along well with each other."

Get over – To recover from something, like an illness or a breakup.

Example: "It took him a while to get over the flu."

Get away – To escape or leave.

Example: "The thief got away before the police arrived."

5. Put

Put off – To delay or postpone something.

Example: "They put off the meeting until next week."

Put up with – To tolerate something unpleasant.

Example: "I can't put up with this noise any longer."

Put on – To wear clothing or accessories.

Example: "She put on her jacket and left."

6. Turn

Turn up – To appear unexpectedly or increase volume/intensity.

Example: "He turned up at the party uninvited."

Example: "Can you turn up the music?"

Turn down – To refuse or reject an offer or lower the volume.

Example: "She turned down the job offer."

Example: "Please turn down the volume."

Turn out – To result in a particular way.

Example: "The event turned out better than expected."

Contextual Word Use

- Understanding when certain words are appropriate for specific contexts is crucial but challenging. Students often struggle with recognizing formal versus informal contexts.

  Example: Using slang like "cool" or "awesome" in formal writing or conversations with authority figures.

- Conversely, students may use overly formal language in casual contexts, such as "I would like to express my gratitude" in a casual text to a friend, where "Thanks!" would suffice.

Sentence Structure Errors

- It occur when the components of a sentence (subject, verb, object, etc.) are arranged incorrectly, leading to confusion, awkward phrasing, or grammatical mistakes.
- These errors are common among non native speakers and can range from basic to complex mistakes.

Run-on Sentences

- A run-on sentence occurs when two or more independent clauses (complete sentences) are joined incorrectly without proper punctuation or conjunctions.
- **Incorrect:** "I went to the store I bought some milk."
- **Correct:** "I went to the store, and I bought some milk."
- **Explanation:** The two clauses are independent and should be separated by a conjunction (e.g., "and") or punctuation (comma, semicolon).

Sentence Fragments

- A sentence fragment is an incomplete sentence that lacks a subject, verb, or both. It may also be a dependent clause that isn’t connected to an independent clause.
- **Incorrect:** "Because I was tired"
- **Correct:** "I went to bed early because I was tired."
- **Explanation:** "Because I was tired" is a dependent clause and cannot stand alone. It needs an independent clause to complete the thought.

Misplaced Modifiers

- A misplaced modifier is a word, phrase, or clause that is placed too far from the word it describes, creating confusion or unintended meanings.
- **Incorrect:** "She served sandwiches to the children on paper plates."
- **Correct:** "She served the children, sandwiches on paper plates."
- **Explanation:** The original sentence implies that the children were on paper plates, but the plates are meant for the sandwiches.

Subject-Verb Agreement Errors

- In English, the verb must agree with the subject in number (singular or plural). Mistakes often occur when learners incorrectly match singular subjects with plural verbs, or vice versa.
- **Incorrect:** "She *go* to the market every day."
- **Correct:** "She *goes* to the market every day."
- **Explanation:** The subject "she" is singular, so the verb should be in the singular form (*goes*).

Dangling Modifiers

- A dangling modifier occurs when the word or phrase being modified is missing from the sentence, leading to ambiguity.
- **Incorrect:** "Walking through the park, the flowers were beautiful."
- **Correct:** "Walking through the park, I saw beautiful flowers."
- **Explanation:** In the incorrect sentence, it’s unclear who is walking through the park. The modifier "Walking through the park" should refer to the subject "I."

Word Order Errors

- English follows a specific word order (Subject-Verb-Object). When learners deviate from this structure, it can lead to confusion.
- **Incorrect:** "Yesterday went to the store I."
- **Correct:** "I went to the store yesterday."
- **Explanation:** The correct word order is subject ("I") followed by the verb ("went") and the object ("to the store").

Incorrect Use of Clauses

- Mistakes in clause usage often involve confusing dependent and independent clauses or misplacing them in a sentence.
- **Incorrect:** "Although he was tired. He finished his work."
- **Correct:** "Although he was tired, he finished his work."
- **Explanation:** "Although he was tired" is a dependent clause and cannot stand alone as a sentence. It needs to be connected to an independent clause.

Overuse or Underuse of Conjunctions

- Sentences can either lack necessary conjunctions or overuse them, leading to awkward sentence flow.
- **Incorrect:** "I want to go to the movies but I am tired but I will go."
- **Correct:** "I want to go to the movies, but I am tired, so I will stay home."
- **Explanation:** The overuse of "but" makes the sentence sound repetitive and unclear. Varying conjunctions or restructuring the sentence improves clarity.

Inconsistent Tenses

- Inconsistent verb tense usage within a sentence or paragraph can confuse readers, especially when there is a mix of past, present, and future tenses without a clear reason.
- **Incorrect:** "I went to the store, buy some milk, and will go home."
- **Correct:** "I went to the store, bought some milk, and went home."
- **Explanation:** The actions are all in the past, so the tenses should be consistent.

Redundant Phrasing

- Some sentences contain unnecessary repetition of words or ideas, making the sentence longer and more confusing than it needs to be.
- **Incorrect:** "She returned back to her home."
- **Correct:** "She returned to her home."
- **Explanation:** "Returned" already implies going back, so "back" is redundant.

Lack of Pronoun Reference

- Sometimes, learners may use a pronoun without making it clear what it refers to.
- **Incorrect:** "When John met Mike, he was tired."
- **Correct:** "When John met Mike, John was tired."
- **Explanation:** It's unclear who "he" refers to in the incorrect sentence. Repeating the subject clarifies the meaning.